



ESCOMB SAXON CHURCH

THE MOST
DISTINGUISHED
SURNAME
MENDENHALL

TABLE OF CONTENTS

SURNAME HISTORY

Ancient History	3
Spelling Variations	3
Early History	5
Early Notables	5
The Great Migration	7
Current Notables	9

SURNAME SYMBOLISM

Introduction	11
Motto	12
Shield	12
Crest	14

FURTHER READINGS AND BIBLIOGRAPHY

Suggested Further Readings	17
Appendix - Notable List	17
Appendix - Settler List	18
Bibliography	20
Citations	24





While your recent ancestors and famous people bearing your surname may be known to you, it is often a family's distant past which fades into the unknown over the centuries. Research has shown that this surname is of Anglo-Saxon origin. Few cultures have had the lasting impact on English society as that of the Anglo-Saxons. The Mendenhall family history draws upon this heritage as the bearers of the name influenced and were influenced by the history of the English nation. Historians have carefully scrutinized such ancient manuscripts as the Domesday Book, compiled in 1086 A.D., the Ragman Rolls (1291-1296), the Curia Regis Rolls, the Pipe Rolls, the Hearth Rolls, parish registers, baptismals, tax records and other ancient documents and found the first record of the name Mendenhall in Suffolk at Mildenhall, a small market town and civil parish which dates back to c. 1050 when it was listed as Mildenhale. By the time of the Domesday Book of 1086, the town was listed as Mitdenehalla and possibly meant "middle nook of land," having derived from the Old English words middel + halh. Mildenhall is also a village and civil parish in the Kennet Valley in Wiltshire and this village dates back further to 803 when it was listed as Mildanhald. Over one hundred years later, the village was listed as Mildenhalle in the Domesday Book.^[1] But it is in the Suffolk town that we find the first occurrence of the surname for in 1170 Andrew Mildenhale was listed as holding estates in that county. The Mildenhall Treasure is a major hoard of highly decorated Roman silver tableware from the fourth-century AD, found at West Row, near Mildenhall in 1942 by Gordon Butler while ploughing.

SPELLING VARIATIONS

Many different spellings of the surname were found in the archives researched. Although the spelling Mendenhall occurred in many manuscripts, from time to time the surname was spelt Mildenhall, Mindenhall, Mendenhall and Miltonhall, and these spelling variations were frequent, even between father and son. It was common to find the same individual referred to with different spellings of their surname. By example, the famous playwright William Shakespeare signed his name with different spellings and legal documents added further to the possible variations. "Shakespeare," "Shakespere," "Shakespear," "Shakspere" and "Shaxspere" were all used in reference to this famous individual. Typically, scribes, church officials and the bearers of a name spelled words as they sounded rather than adhering to any spelling rules used today.





The Saxons were a Teutonic tribe originally from northern Germany who began to settle in England in about the year 400 A.D. Their first settlements were in Kent, on the south east coast. Gradually, they probed north and westward from Kent and during the next four hundred years forced the ancient Britons back into Wales and Cornwall to the west. They won territories as far north as Lancashire and Yorkshire, pushing the Britons into Cumbria and Southern Scotland. The Angles, another Teutonic tribe, occupied the eastern coast, the south folk in Suffolk, the north folk in Norfolk. The Angles sometimes invaded as far north as Northumbria and the Scottish border. The Angle and Saxon cultures blended together as they came to dominate the country. For hundreds of years England was comprised of five independent Anglo-Saxon kingdoms until unification in the 9th century. By 1066, England, under Harold, was enjoying reasonable peace and prosperity. However, the Norman invasion from France and their victory at the Battle of Hastings meant that the Anglo-Saxon landowners lost their property to the invaders. The Saxons were restive under Norman rule, and many moved northward to the Midlands, Lancashire and Yorkshire, where Norman influence was less pervasive. Rebellious Norman nobles frequently joined them in their flight northward.

As peace was restored, the Mendenhall surname emerged as that of a notable English family in the county of Suffolk where they held a family seat at Bury St. Edmunds. The family later branched to Wiltshire although we have been unable to find a location. The name is believed to have been Minsterchamber originally and may have originated in Huntingdon at Stuston. From their early beginnings, for the next few centuries, bearers of the family name acquired estates and manors as they established themselves throughout England. Major conflicts, such as the Wars of the Roses (1455-1487), and the Cromwellian Civil Wars (17th century), sometimes found family members to be in opposing camps, with conflicting interests.

EARLY NOTABLES

Distinguished members of the family include John Mildenhall (1560-1614) or John Midnall, a British explorer and adventurer and one of the first to make an overland journey to India. He was the self-styled ambassador of the British East India Company in India and was the first recorded burial of an Englishman in India.



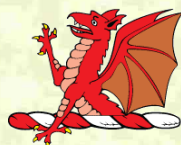


Turmoil at home made the New World appear attractive to many families in England. They immigrated to Canada, the United States, Australia, and some moved to continental Europe. Members of the Mendenhall family risked the hazardous voyage to start a new life in new lands. This decision to emigrate was never made casually, for while there were hardships at home, the journey across the sea was so perilous that up to 40 percent of a ships' passengers would not reach their destination.

SETTLERS

- H Mendenhall, who landed in San Francisco, California in 1851^[2]
- Mrs. Mendenhall, aged 40, who settled in America, in 1894
- Fanny C. Mendenhall, aged 63, who immigrated to the United States, in 1903
- Grace Mendenhall, aged 26, who settled in America, in 1903
- H.G. Mendenhall, who landed in America, in 1904
- Joshua Mendenhall, who landed in America, in 1905
- Stella Mendenhall, who immigrated to the United States, in 1905
- James Mendenhall, aged 31, who immigrated to the United States from Bournemouth, in 1906
- Hettie Mendenhall, aged 62, who settled in America, in 1908
- Emma Mendenhall, aged 30, who landed in America, in 1909
- Charles Mendenhall, aged 26, who immigrated to the United States, in 1910
- Lawrence Mendenhall, aged 55, who immigrated to the United States, in 1910
- Georgiana Mendenhall, aged 32, who landed in America, in 1911
- Dorothy Mendenhall, aged 57, who landed in America, in 1912
- Henry Mendenhall, aged 46, who immigrated to the United States, in 1917
- Margory Mendenhall, aged 24, who landed in America, in 1917

As well as 13 more in the Appendix.





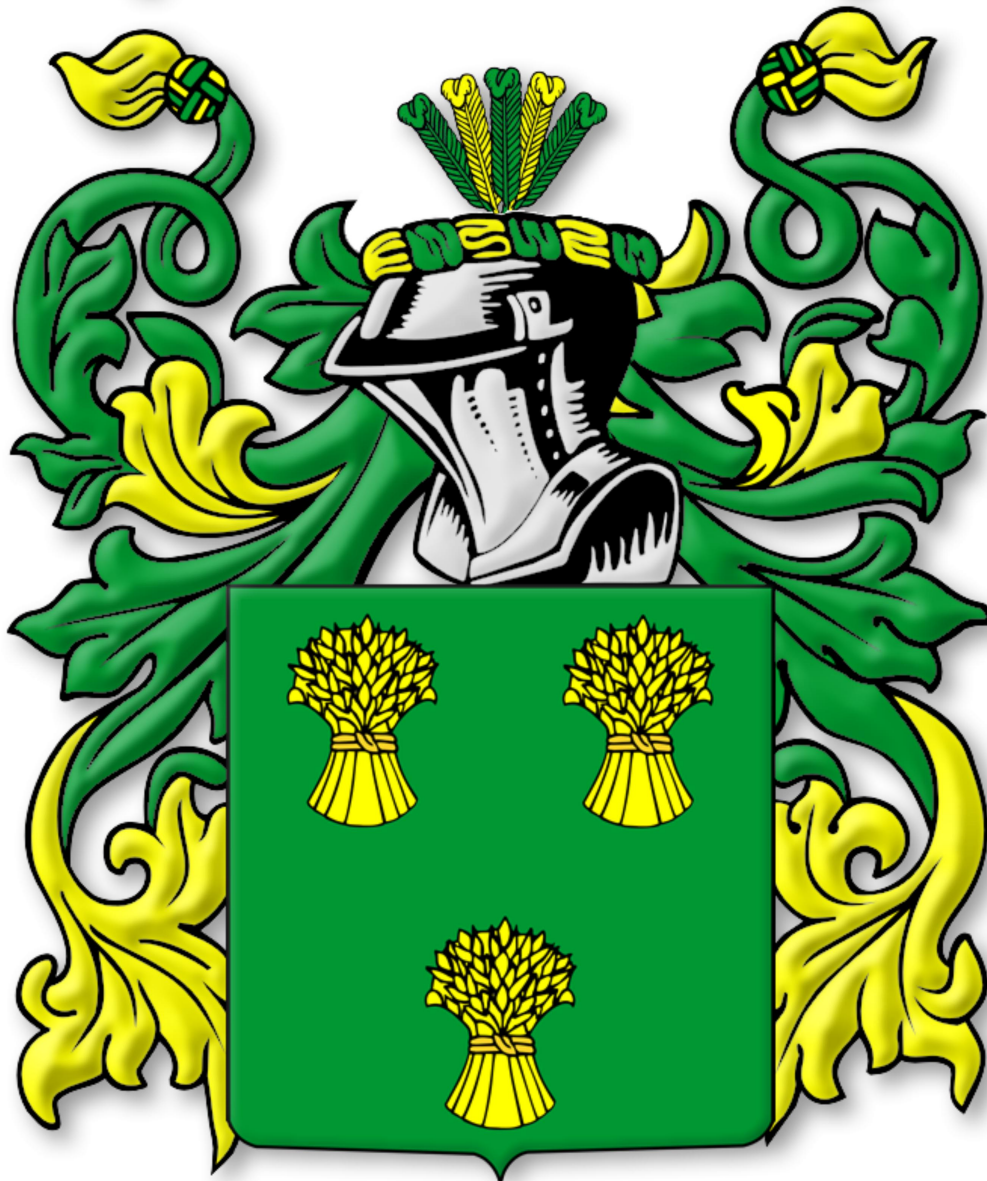
CURRENT NOTABLES

By the time of the American Revolution (1775-1783), the colonial population had reached approximately 2.5 million people. Black slaves constituted roughly 22 percent of the total; about 250,000 were Scots-Irish; approximately 200,000 were Germans. Protestants formed the overwhelming majority of white people, although approximately 25,000 Roman Catholics and about 1000 Jews also lived in the colonies. Approximately 50,000 people loyal to the British crown made their way north to Canada following the American Revolution. They were known as the United Empire Loyalists, and were granted lands in Nova Scotia, along the St. Lawrence River and along the Niagara Peninsula.

- George Emery Mendenhall (1916-2016) American author and Professor Emeritus at the University of Michigan
- Murray Mendenhall Jr. (1925-2014) American professional basketball player and coach
- Sammi Mendenhall (b.1968) American Casting Director, Writer, and Producer
- Dorothy Mabel Reed Mendenhall (1874-1964) well known American pediatrician
- Mathew W. Mendenhall (b.1957) former American football defensive end
- Ken E. Mendenhall (b.1948) former American football center
- Joseph A. Mendenhall (b.1920) U.S. State Department official
- Thomas Corwin Mendenhall (1841-1924) autodidact American physicist and meteorologist
- David Mendenhall (b.1971) American actor and former child actor
- Rashard Jamal Mendenhall (b.1987) American football running back

As well as 7 more in the Appendix.

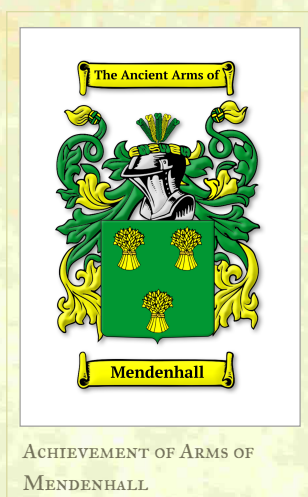
The Ancient Arms of



Mendenhall



The practice of representing people with symbols is ancient, and in England this habit evolved with feudal society into a system of distinctive devices on shields. The heralds developed an extensive armory that had the important function of distinguishing members of the upper class from each other, whether at court or on the battlefield. Since then, heraldry has grown into a complex field with many rules and a terminology that requires some knowledge to interpret.



An Achievement of Arms such as the Mendenhall arms depicted on the left typically consists of these parts: the Escrolls, displaying the family motto and name, the family crest (if any) seen above the helmet, the actual Coat of arms (also known as 'arms,' or 'the shield'), the Helmet depicted below the crest, the Torse on top of the helmet, and the Mantle draped from the helmet. Each of these elements will be described below. Supporters were a later addition to the Achievement; they are somewhat rare, and are usually personal to the grantee.



MANTLE OF MENDENHALL

The mantle was spread over and draped from the helmet and served as a protection, 'to repel the extremities of wet, cold, and heat, and to preserve the armour from rust.' The numerous cuts and slits suggest that it had been torn and hacked on the field of battle. The style or design of the mantling is up to the individual heraldic artist, and it is usually depicted in the main color and metal from the shield. The helmet (or Helm) varied in shape in different ages and countries, often depicting rank. The Esquire's Helm, as depicted here, is generally shown silver, with a closed visor and facing to the dexter (its right). On top of the helmet is a Torse or wreath which was formed by two pieces of silk twisted together. Its purpose was to hold the crest and mantle on the Helm.

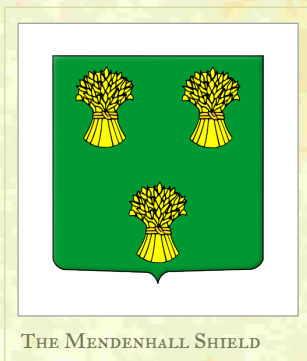
MOTTO

The motto was originally a war cry or slogan. Mottoes first began to be shown with arms in the 14th and 15th centuries, but were not in general use until the 17th century. Thus the oldest coats of arms generally do not include a motto. Mottoes seldom form part of the grant of arms: Under most heraldic authorities, a motto is an optional component of the coat of arms, and can be added to or changed at will; many families have chosen not to display a motto.

The coat of arms displayed here for the surname Mendenhall did not include a motto.

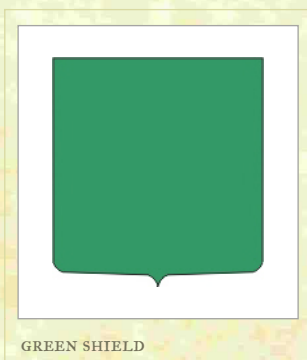
SHIELD

Shields (or Escutcheons) at first were painted simply with one or more bands of color or 'ordinaries'. Later, the ordinaries were used in conjunction with other figures or symbols. The Coat of Arms for the surname Mendenhall can be described as follows:



MENDENHALL ARMS

A green shield with three gold wheat sheaves.



GREEN SHIELD

"Vert" (from the French word for green) signifies felicity and pleasure. It was symbolic of joy, youth and beauty. Green was also associated with the spring. The bearer of the green is obliged to defend the peasant and all who work on the land. It is expressed in engravings by lines in bend, or slanting to the right.

Symbolic Virtues: Green denotes the virtues of charity and hope, as well as the qualities of honor, courtesy and abundance.

Precious Stone: Emerald

Planet: Venus

Obligations: To defend the peasant and all who work on the land

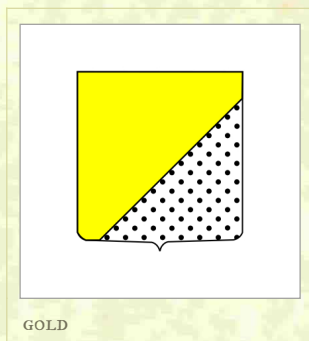
THREE

"Three" devices, beasts or ordinaries of the same have a special significance in heraldry.

First of all, there is the obvious reference to the Trinity in the design that would signify observance of the Christian doctrine.

Secondly, with many Arms it brings balance that is steeped in tradition. To better understand this latter scenario, we must look at the evolution of shield in personal armory. Kite shields that were the most popular from the the 10th-14th century evolved into Heater shields that had flat tops c. 1250. This was the time of heraldry's beginnings and when "three" objects were used for balance in each corner of the shield.

Later, with the advent of the "chief," "chevron" and "bend" three devices brought balance to these ordinaries too.



GOLD

"Or" (from the French word for gold) is the tincture of Gold, or in heraldic terms "or," was considered the noblest color.

One of only two metals used in heraldry, it exceeds all others in value, purity and finesse. It represents the light of the sun, and was once borne only by princes. Gold is said to gladden the heart and destroy all works of magic. It is also associated with excellence and achievement, and the bearer surpasses all others in valor.

It is represented on coats of arms by the color yellow, and in engravings by a dotted pattern.

THE CREST

The Crest was worn on top of the helmet, and was usually made of wood, metal, or boiled leather. It provided the double advantage of easy identification and the addition of height to the wearer. If a family had no crest, and many chose not to, plumes (feathers) were often displayed instead.



SUGGESTED FURTHER READINGS

"Ancestors and Descendants of Jacob H. Mendenhall and his Wife Hannah W. Newlin" by Lillian Mendenhall Powell Jacobs.

"The Mendenhalls: a Genealogy" by Henry Hart Beeson.

Please note: We do not have these publications in our library. They come from the catalog of Genealogical titles in the collection of the Library of Congress. Most of these Genealogies were published by their authors, probably with one small print run. You can locate these publications through the Library of Congress (<http://catalog.loc.gov/webvoy.htm>), or we would suggest trying to contact a library in the locale of publication (you may be able to use inter-library loan, through your local library).





APPENDIX - NOTABLE LIST

NOTABLES FOR THE SURNAME MENDENHALL

- George Emery Mendenhall (1916-2016) American author and Professor Emeritus at the University of Michigan
- Murray Mendenhall Jr. (1925-2014) American professional basketball player and coach
- Sammi Mendenhall (b.1968) American Casting Director, Writer, and Producer
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- Joseph A. Mendenhall (b.1920) U.S. State Department official
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- David Mendenhall (b.1971) American actor and former child actor
- Rashard Jamal Mendenhall (b.1987) American football running back

SURNAME VARIANTS OF MENDENHALL

- William James "Jack" Mildenhall (1891-1962) Australian photographer and civil servant, best known for having photographed construction of the new Australian capital, Canberra in the 1920s and 1930s
- Jonathan Mildenhall, British Chief Marketing Officer at Airbnb, former Vice President at the Coca-Cola Company
- Bill Mildenhall (b.1953) Australian former basketball referee in the National Basketball League and Australian rules footballer
- Andrew Mildenhall (b.1966) former English cricketer who played from 1989 to 1990 for Wiltshire
- Neil Mildenhall (b.1968) Australian rules footballer who played for the Fremantle Dockers in 1995
- Bruce Allan Mildenhall (b.1953) Australian politician, Member of the Victorian Legislative Assembly for Footscray (1992-2006)
- Stephen James "Steve" Mildenhall (b.1979) English football goalkeeper



AMERICAN SETTLERS

- H Mendenhall, who landed in San Francisco, California in 1851 ^[2]
- Mrs. Mendenhall, aged 40, who settled in America, in 1894
- Fanny C. Mendenhall, aged 63, who immigrated to the United States, in 1903
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- Georgiana Mendenhall, aged 32, who landed in America, in 1911
- Dorothy Mendenhall, aged 57, who landed in America, in 1912
- Henry Mendenhall, aged 46, who immigrated to the United States, in 1917
- Margory Mendenhall, aged 24, who landed in America, in 1917
- Orson Mendenhall, who landed in America, in 1920
- John Mendenhall, aged 22, who immigrated to America, in 1921
- James A. Mendenhall, aged 24, who landed in America, in 1922
- Edith E. Mendenhall, aged 24, who immigrated to America from London, England, in 1923
- William Orville Mendenhall, aged 44, who settled in America, in 1923

SURNAME VARIANTS OF MENDENHALL

- John Mildenhall, aged 48, who arrived in America from Ansham, England, in 1907

NEW ZEALAND SETTLERS

SURNAME VARIANTS OF MENDENHALL

- Stephen Mildenhall, aged 26, a shepherd, who arrived in Wellington, New Zealand aboard the ship "La Hogue" in 1874
- Emma R. Mildenhall, aged 22, who arrived in Wellington, New Zealand aboard the ship "La Hogue" in 1874
- Frank R. Mildenhall, aged 8 months, who arrived in Wellington, New Zealand aboard the ship "La Hogue" in 1874
- Mr. Alfred Mildenhall, (b. 1853), aged 21, English settler from Berkshire travelling from London aboard the ship "Sussex" arriving in Port Chalmers, Dunedin, Otago, South Island, New Zealand on 17th July 1874 ^[3]
- Mrs. Sarah Mildenhall, (b. 1852), aged 22, English settler from Berkshire travelling from London aboard the ship "Sussex" arriving in Port Chalmers, Dunedin, Otago, South Island, New Zealand on 17th July 1874 ^[3]





Here is a listing of some of the sources consulted when researching British surnames. The resources below directly or indirectly influenced the authors of our surname histories. We have most of these titles in our library, others we have borrowed or had access to. Source materials have been chosen for their reliability and authenticity. Our research into surnames is ongoing, and we are continually adding to our source library. For each surname history, we seek and refer to sources specific to the surname; these are generally not included in the list below.

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TRUSTED WEB-SITES

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Library and Archives Canada:
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United Kingdom National Archives:
<http://www.nationalarchives.gov.uk/>

The National Archives (USA): <http://www.archives.gov/>

College of Arms (England): <http://college-of-arms.gov.uk/>

MEDIEVAL ROLLS

Where available we consult Medieval rolls or use their information as reprinted in secondary sources.

Subsidy Rolls: taxation records from the 12th to the 17th centuries.

Assize Rolls: records from court sessions

Pipe Rolls: rolls of the Exchequer of accounts of the royal income, arranged by county, for each financial year. Many 12th and 13th century documents have been published with indexes by the Pipe Roll Society.

Calendarium Inquisitionum Post Mortem: Feudal inquiries, undertaken after the death of a feudal tenant in chief to establish what lands were held and who should succeed to them. Records exist from around 1240-1660.

Roll of Battle Abbey: a list of the principal Norman Knights said to have accompanied William across the English Channel. Original roll was lost.

Curia Regis Rolls (*Rotuli Curiae Regis*): Rolls and Records of the Court held before the king's Justices. Various translated and published, London 1835),

Feet of Fines: Legal agreements, usually about property ownership

Register of the Freeman of York: list of freemen from 13th-18th century, published by the Surtees Society, Francis Collins (editor) in 1897.

Charters: documents recording grants, usually of land recorded by the Chancery

Historia Regum Britanniae ("The History of the Kings of Britain"): a legendary account of British history, accredited to Geoffrey of Monmouth in around 1136.

Heralds' visitations: 16th-17th century, county by county visits to regulate the use of arms; many published by the Harleian Society.

Hundred Rolls (*Rotuli Hundredorum*): various royal inquests, documents were held in the tower of London. Much was published in 1818 Ragman Rolls: rolls of deeds on parchment in which the Scottish nobility and gentry subscribed allegiance to Edward I. of England, A. D. 1296.

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